Part of my future

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/57873940.

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by Da_Koda

Summary

Catra doesn't understand why Adora came back for her. Feeling guilty and angry, she finally forces her to talk about their past together.

Notes

Greetings! This is the first time I'm writing fanfiction in English, the experience was unforgettable. I want to warn you that this work is pretty short. The episode itself is a missing scene from my head that was supposed to happen between Catra and Adora after escaping from Prime's ship. Hope you'll like it!

— Koda

"Why can't you get it?" Catra's fingers clench the back of her head in their habitual panic, chaotically trying to find the torn-out chip. Her voice echoed off the walls of First one's spaceship, but the closed doors ensured the privacy of their conversation. "I didn't ask you to come back for me."

"Catra," Adora takes a few small steps forward, placing her hand gently on the girl's shoulder as if afraid to scare her off. She pulls away at the same moment, realizing that she could only make things worse with that gesture: "We had to get to Prime's ship at any cost. We couldn't risk Glimmer's life."

Adora fidgets awkwardly, still not quite sure whether to try to calm her down with a hug, as in the old days of the Horde, or not to violate her personal boundaries and start from afar: to steer the conversation in a direction that would most likely lead to another fight. Her gaze swings between Catra's restless tail and her eyes full of familiar resentment, rage, and guilt.

"Then we saved you," Adora stopped talking and sat down on the edge of the bed with a heavy sigh, tapping lightly on the railing to invite Catra to sit beside her. "It was reckless and stupid, especially on my part, but Glimmer said you sacrificed yourself to help her."

"Exactly," her calm tone changes to an irritated hiss. "I did everything I could to send Sparkles back to you. Did I ask you to come back for me?"

"No," Adora frowned, and before Catra could say anything else, she exhaled, "But we couldn't leave you there. I couldn't leave you there. You may have been able to overthrow Hordak and subdue him, but this is Hord Prime we're talking about, Catra. Look what he did to you."

"You think I don't know?" Patience is replaced by familiar stubbornness. Catra irritably brushes her protruding ears back against her head and turns away, showing with all her appearance

that she doesn't like this conversation. But it's impossible to avoid it. "You think I wanted to come back? No. I don't care what Prime would do to me if I stayed there. There's no place for me in Etheria, and you know it."

"Enough," a hand gripped the other's shoulder firmly, forcing Catra to turn to face the speaker. "There's place for everyone in Etheria, and you're no exception. When we defeat Prime..."

"Have you really become so naive because of your beloved princesses?" Catra chuckles, but her voice isn't happy at all. Facing Adora, she looks into her blue eyes, as if trying to find an answer to her own question. "We can't defeat him. Sooner or later he'll figure out how to activate the weapon, and then even the great and mighty She-Ra won't be able to do anything. Open your eyes."

"You're insufferable."

"This will be a lesson not to save me when I ask you not to," Catra immediately replies, to which she gets an angry look and another heavy sigh. Rest after the dangerous space adventure is postponed for later.

"If you hate me so much, then please! Sit in your cell, feel sorry for yourself, be afraid of every rustle and shadow," Adora gets up abruptly from her bed and walks out, not wanting to waste any more of her energy on a dead-end conversation that turned out to be an extremely stupid idea. "I thought you'd changed to help Glimmer, but I guess I was wrong."

"Wait," Catra instinctively stands behind her, nervously running her own tail over her fingers.

Both of them are silent now. The right words are desperately on their tongues, but pride and stubbornness make it much harder to speak.

"You made a promise," Catra finally swallowed and stepped forward, putting an arm around her shoulders in an attempt to

lend credence to her own words. "Remember? Being together, always. Back in the Horde, you said you'd always be at my side, and we had to look out for each other. You were my family."

Adora pushes her lower lip up, turning her full attention to the speaker. The sudden anger and irritation recedes, giving way to new emotions; guilt spills unpleasantly cold from within, forcing the girl to stay. To get to the end of the conversation.

"You left. Maybe it's nothing to you, I don't know," her voice is traitorously hoarse, and her eyes are trying to find something to focus on and keep her feelings at bay, which is probably pointless. The drooping tail and her slumped posture betray the bitter truth. "But I remember in detail the day we first stepped outside the Fright Zone. The ship crashed, you found the sword, then you became a princess and you just... ran away."

Adora squints, knowing exactly where Catra is taking this dialog, and waits. She doesn't dare interrupt - just waits for the point of no return when the former Horde commander, her close friend, will break down, crack, and spill everything she's always wanted to say with no running away. Today, at least.

"You made a promise," Catra clenched her fingers into fists and looked at Adora with childish resentment, either wanting to punch her in the face or trying to control herself. Ingrown fingernails scratch unpleasantly at the rough skin on the inside. "And you broke it. After so many years, after so many trainings, sleepovers, games and adventures together, you left me alone in the Horde, going off to people you'd known for.... for how long? A day? That sounds ridiculous."

It wasn't funny, not to her, not to Adora. The other one doesn't dare to speak, just stares silently at the girl in front of her. Her hand reaches out to gently stroke her back, giving her some reassurance, and this time no one stops her. Taking a couple more steps towards Catra, Adora takes her into her arms and waits a second, two - she doesn't pull away.

"What the hell, Adora?" Catra buries her face into the other's shoulder. She doesn't want to look up yet. "It's like everyone's gone crazy since you left: Hordak, Shadow Weaver... I guess I've gone crazy, too. I was scared and lonely because I knew in my heart that you weren't coming back. Even if you'd hate it. Even if you'd hate me."

"I never hated you, Catra."

"I stopped waiting for you when I became a force captain," her fingers reached for the left side of her chest, indicating the absence of her lovely green badge, "What's the use of waiting for someone who won't choose you in the end? I tried to forget everything that happened between us, but even so, the sight of you made me want to run away and scream with anger. All our memories from the Horde were nothing to you, apparently."

Adora looks around. The walls of the cabin distort, taking on the appearance of the old corridors of Fright Zone: crates of supplies and weapons everywhere, some still bearing the marks of small claws. Somewhere out there, behind the piles of metal and the junkyard of parts for massive war machines, is their secret lair. A hiding place filled with painful but dear to their hearts childhood memories, where not even Shadow Weaver could reach them.

She remembers everything. She remembers Catra running away from Octavia when she lost an eye to her friend's mischief. Adora never thought it was fun though, but the excited little ears twitching from the adrenaline rush and the other's mischievous smile meant the world to her. She also remembered how Catra had been desperately jealous of her and Lonnie, thinking that eventually Adora would lose interest in her and go off to join other kids, leaving her behind. If only she knew that even if there were a hundred cool cadets on the training field, Adora wouldn't even look in their direction - Catra was always the priority. She wanted to protect her not only from the Shadow Weaver, but also from her own dangerous pranks, which was perhaps sometimes more difficult than the first thing.

She remembers a time when Catra kept a low profile in their secret place, for in case of illness, it was best for a cadet to lay low and take care of their condition without showing any signs of weakness, rather than die on purpose: if any adult noticed, you were already dead. They didn't have much medicine, and there was nowhere to steal it from, so all Adora could do was sneak behind the old blocks in her spare time and sit with her sick friend, changing pieces of wet clothes and soaking them again to regulate her body temperature; stocking up on vitamin bars and making a healthy gray mass out of them - it couldn't be called cooking, though. No such concept existed in the Horde. Neither does caring for each other.

The children's laughter reminds Adora that she's still in the room. The walls return to their former appearance, the piles of junk and tools disappearing as if at the snap of a finger. The last thing that caught her eye was the tip of a small dark gray tail hiding under the blocks along with burning mismatched eyes. It wasn't a childish version of Catra now; there was no playful grin or moving tail flicking back and forth in anticipation of another prank. Instead, it was just a slumped stare with hunched shoulders and years of resentment that she can't hold back any longer.

"I'm so sorry," Adora hugged Catra tightly around the shoulders and pulled her against her own chest, making feline ears catch the beating of another's heart. "I never wanted you to think you meant nothing to me at all. The Rebellion gave me a new start in life, helping those in trouble who truly need it. I've made new friends and seen the world, but that's not all."

Catra's eyes stubbornly avoided eye contact, jumping from one object to another. She isn't used to being vulnerable, and Adora knows it: she can feel herself sputtering with anxiety and anger, this time directed at herself for being too sincere.

"Look at me. Please," Adora's voice was soft, almost caressing, and so familiar that Catra's lower lip trembled involuntarily. Her palm reaches up to her cheeks, gently stroking her cheekbones with her thumb, following the invisible patterns on the rough skin.

There's as much pain in the blue eyes as in her own, and there's no need for lies. Even Adora's touch is drenched in sincerity and affection, making Catra feel safe for a second.

She lifts her gaze from the floor and slowly, as if doubting whether this is reality or a sick dream, presses Adora's hand to her cheek, feeling the warmth of the human touch. Tears come to her eyes, but Catra resolutely ignores them: all she cares about now is the outcome of the conversation. The phrase Adora has to say will either tear her heart to shreds, or it will finally free her from her pain and give her a chance to open up.

"I missed you," her voice becomes a whisper. Adora gently wipes a tear off from the girl's face and smiles, looking into her confused, guilty eyes. "I missed you, Katra. Bright Moon became my home, just like people from here, but there's never been a day when I didn't think of you. I knew we could never go back to the relationship we had in the Horde, and it hurt so much. It hurt to realize that the closest person who meant the world to me was just a part of the past."

Catra's fingers involuntarily clutched the fabric of the white uniform as remorse, anger, and joy mingled together. The words heard from the lips of her loved one should have reassured her, reassured her that she was not a monster in the eyes of others. At least not as horrible as she was in her own. However, instead of the peace of mind she wanted, there was only one thing she felt - a nasty, guilt-soaked sadness.

"I've always wanted you to be a part of my present," Adora's grip loosens, and Catra tilts her head in confusion, sensing a slight change in her tone: tenderness gives way to grief, and her voice becomes more serious. "A part of my future. Perhaps the Stars have heard me, since our saving operation was successful, and now we are together, but..."

"It's not what you wanted," Catra guesses, and finishes the other's thought aloud, letting go of her clothes. She stares silently at the floor for a while, listening to the rhythmic noise from the

vent system, and then looks up at Adora, squeezing her palm confidently in her own. "Etheria needs you. It needs Sparkles, that arrow boy..."

"And you," Adora raises an eyebrow with a serious expression, making it clear she's not joking. "We may have to continue this conversation in the near future, but not before saving our home."

"I still don't understand why you're so naive," Catra rolls her eyes, but the start of another banter ends here. She lets go of Adora's hand and stares into the other's eyes for a few moments, then pulls back, remembering that this intimacy is taking too long.

"Don't worry, you'll become one too," Adora let out a quiet laugh, more like an awkward giggle, and headed for the door, not to end the conversation on a bad note this time, but to join the rest of the crew and make a new plan to save their home planet once and for all.

"Never going to happen."

Catra would prefer her room to royal society. Her relationship with Adora may be starting to improve - at least she doesn't hate her - but the rest of the rescue crew still treats her like a prisoner.

When a click sounds, the obvious signal of an open corridor passage, Adora pauses for a moment and looks back at Catra one last time with a slight smile that makes the dimples in her cheeks noticable.

"I'm glad you're okay."

"Just go away already."

The door closes with a clang. The next stop is an unknown planet that once managed to fight back and scared Prime for good. Adora's "naivety" is probably contagious, because now the idea of saving Etheria doesn't seem so stupid - princesses are good for something after all.

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